lexicon of prejudice. When we hear the word "racism," we generally know what is meant, and we understand that it can manifest against people of color in different ways. Even "Islamophobia," a relatively recent term coined by Muslim advocacy organizations, enjoys a wide consensus as to its meaning, even though that meaning includes forthright critiques of Islam as a faith as well as crudely bigoted attitudes towards Muslims. Consider: in the context of non-Muslim attitudes towards Muslims, the right to reject religion, the right even to engage in blasphemy, an integral right in western societies, is now regarded as a form of racism![12]

But antisemitism is different. To simplify, whereas there is a consensus recognition of antisemitism as, historically, a presence in the lives of Jews who are now dead, there is no similar consensus recognition of its presence in the lives of Jews who are currently alive.

Why is this case? I want to suggest two principal reasons. First, the perspectives and experiences of minorities who suffer from prejudice tend to be privileged in our understanding of how these prejudices function. It is generally assumed that if a person of color complains of racism, there is likely to be a credible basis for such a claim, or at the very least a recognition that we are dealing with a claim that cannot be dismissed out of hand. Crucially, minorities "own" the definition of these descriptors, so that we automatically infer that the victims of what is called "racism" are people of color. This is not always the case with the Jews. With growing frequency, it is assumed that the real victims of what is called "antisemitism" are not Jews, but those who are unfairly branded as antisemites.

This brings me to the second, related, reason: Jews do not own the term "antisemitism" in the way that people of color own the term "racism." Indeed, they never have. When the term emerged in Germany in the late 1870s, its authors proudly described themselves as "antisemites"—a term they coined because, they believed, it encapsulated a scientific instead of a theological approach to what was known as the "Jewish Question" or the "Jewish Problem." The first generation of antisemites portrayed themselves not as prophets of hate and bearers of unreason, but as agents of liberation. Under the cover of a discourse of freedom, antisemitism shaped up as a social and political program that aimed at the control or outright removal of Jewish influence from non-Jewish polities.

Within less than a century, however, the term antisemitism was widely regarded, including by antisemites themselves, as a term that had outlived its usefulness, and moreover one used for the purposes of moral blackmail by Jewish and non-Jewish critics of anti-Jewish discourse. These days, we often hear anti-Zionists protest that they are accused of antisemitism in order to

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